

How we Test



It looks good and the technology is glitzy, but does it do the job?

Reviewers at the Digital Media Test & Research Centre (DMTRC) spend many manhours every month testing hardware and software to guide Digit readers to make an informed choice when faced with a buying decision. At the core of the tests is the usability and the relevance of the technology for the readers of Digit.

To ensure that the Indian readers do not have to compromise on quality, engineers at DMTRC evaluate and review the latest hardware, software and technology services in accordance with the most cutting-edge evaluation processes and methodologies used around the world.



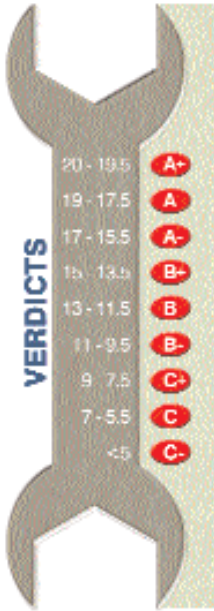
given below is used in applying the overall grades to these products based upon the overall scores.

In the case of the comparison tests, the weightages are applied to the various test parameters according to their importance. This is explained in the magazine articles and in the Test Process section of the CD, where the benchmarking methodology is explained in detail.



The Awards

Digit rewards exceptional performance in each comparison test by picking a Best Performance winner. This award goes to the product that outshines the competition in our performance benchmarks. The Best Value award, on the other hand, is awarded to the product that we feel has the best combination of price and performance. Consider this your yardstick if you are looking for more value for your money.



Demystifying the ratings

The DMTRC conducts two kinds of tests/reviews in the Test Drive section of the magazine—standalone product reviews as well as comparison tests. The test process is elaborate. We test an assortment of hardware and software products from the Indian market, and the evaluation processes involve parameters such as sheer performance, build quality, value for money and the features of the product. A set of weightages are applied to these evaluation parameters to arrive at an overall score. The table

STAR RATINGS	
★★★★★	Excellent: a brilliant combination of price, performance and features, far beyond expectations
★★★★	Good: a good buy, better than most products in its category
★★★	Average: reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product
★★	Mediocre: does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas
★	Poor: contains serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for the target application

In Test this Month

For this month's comparison test we have an assortment of laptops. We got to lay our hands on a selected group of 10 laptops, from the classy Compaqs to the sleek Sharp! As a matter of fact, the Sharp Muramasu PC UM10 literally had the entire Test Centre and the rest of the team drooling. A complete opposite was the brute force solution from ACi—the ACi Xtreme was truly a bully of a laptop with its rather oversized LCD screen.



In the software comparison, we scrounged the Internet for great freeware—the best that's available. Some were old favourites while for other categories we were pleasantly surprised to find some new alternatives that offered great functionality. The freeware revolution clearly continues to thrive.



Mindware

Featured in the Test Drive section of the Mindware CD are 30 great freeware. Go ahead. Try them out for yourself.